

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 129
No. 14



THURSDAY
19TH JUNE, 2025

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 01]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 18]

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*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 19th June, 2025

The House met at 2.55 p.m.

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly turn to the item numbered 5 – Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, page 1...6.

Yes, Hon Member for Tema Central?

Mr Charles Forson: Mr Speaker, page 7—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I have not mentioned page 7.

Mr Forson: All right, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You are running ahead of me; anyways, let us now turn to page 7.

Mr Forson: Mr Speaker, I was in the Chamber, but I have been marked absent.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which item?

Mr Forson: Mr Speaker, it is the item numbered 4(12).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you register your name?

Mr Forson: Yes, I did.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you?

Mr Forson: Yes, I did.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

So, Table Office, kindly check the register, if, indeed, he registered his name, please, acknowledge him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we turn to page 8...9 —

Yes, Hon Member for New Juaben North?

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 9(a) reads, the Hon Minister for “the” Interior. I think that the word “the” should be deleted.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

So, Table Office, kindly take note.

Hon Members, page 10...16 —

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato, other than this, I would not have noticed your presence.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, respectfully, on page 16, it is just a minor but important correction since it borders on identity. The item numbered 3(iii), the name “Ms Regina Dzokoto”, she spells her Djokoto, “D-j-o”. So, I would propose that we *delete* “z” and *insert* “j”.

Then, Mr Speaker, with your permission, the next item numbered 3(iv), a Director at the Ministry of Finance, Mr Anthony Dzadzra, has been designated as Director, Ministry of Finance. I am pretty much aware that there are several directors over there. My checks indicate that he is the Director for Revenue Policy Division at the Ministry of Finance. So, I plead that the Clerks-at-the-Table take a second look at that and then correct accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table Office, kindly take note of the correction on the item numbered 3(iii), but with respect to the correction on the item numbered 3(iv), I am not quite sure because it could be that, at the meeting, the director wrote this designation himself. So, if the director indicated this designation himself, I do not think we can sit here and change it. Unless, on the record, he did that and we have changed it here. I do not know if I am making sense. Normally, at the meeting, one writes his or her name and the designation. So, if the director was here himself and wrote his name and assigned this designation as a “Director, Ministry of Finance”, we cannot sit here and change it.

Yes?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr. Speaker, I am sure if we are not careful, we will be running into absurdity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Exactly.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I would also reckon that, because the *Official Reports* and the *Votes and Proceedings* are documents of Parliament, if we do not get certain things right, we would be producing documents that do not reflect the reality on the outside world. I think that where we have doubt, the Clerks-at-the-Table would have to check with them and correct appropriately, so that we do not just take everything hook, line and sinker of whatever is put on paper. Some people, for brevity, sometimes, just write certain things when actually they would be sending some misleading information. I think that should happen, so that we get our records right.

Mr Afriyie: Mr. Speaker, it is just to add to what my respected Colleague has said. It is not to litigate with you, but I respectfully submit that the Clerks-at-the-Table should check because for example, if we say Chief Whip, it could be Minority Chief Whip or Majority Chief Whip. So, I only submitted that you could alert the Clerks-at-the-Table to check accordingly, so that we get the records right.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, the Table would just do that.

Hon Members, normally, this is just what transpired, so they just report exactly what transpired. So, if the person

came and wrote his name and wrote his designation as this, we cannot sit here and presume that it ought to be something else. That is why we normally maintain this as *Votes and Proceedings*. When we get to the *Official Report*, it is where we do detailed reporting, so the *Votes and Proceedings* normally reports what transpired.

The person came to the meeting and wrote his name and his designation, but if, for instance, he wrote his name and we could not get the name right, we could correct it. However, with respect to the designation, I am a bit — For all you may know, you may think this is his position, but in actual fact, what he may have written is right. So, please, let us — I appreciate where you are coming from.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, for instance, if I go to a meeting and write “speaker” as my designation, when, in reality, I am a speaker of, maybe, a parliament of a school — That confusion should be checked by the Clerks-at-the-Table because following the Member of Parliament raising it, that would help solve the issue and come as corrections.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, Table Office, just cross-check for us.

Let us turn to page 17...19.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and proceedings* of Thursday, 18th June, 2025, as corrected is hereby adopted as a true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, I have in my hands the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 11th June, 2025.

Yes, Hon Member for Effia?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I do not have a copy of the *Official Report* neither do we have it published in the system. But I have a particular concern about the timely distribution of these records for the perusal of Members and further comment. Because these are records that when, at the end of the day, we pass them, they become final representation of proceedings of the House. Inasmuch as we want to digitalise, I am expecting that we should receive it either by our mail, not less than 24 hours before Sitting, so that Members can have time to read through and make the necessary corrections. Because, many times, one goes back into the *Official Report* and they find errors. But then, we would have passed it already in the House, and it is difficult for one to come back and make corrections.

3.05 p.m.

Mr Speaker, so, I need your direction on what the minimum hours or number of days Members may need to get access to these *Official Reports* as well as the *Votes and Proceedings*, so that we are not caught off guard. I have just been smuggled one copy of the *Official Report*, and on what basis are we to read this and approve as a House?

Mr Speaker, please, guide the House.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It is a good concern and I do not want to just sit here and give a fiat. Leadership will have to sit as a whole to take a decision on this. This is because like he said, it is important that the *Official Report* is given in good time, so that Members can actually go through it. So, I share in his concern, but I do not want to sit here and say anything because Parliament is not only about the Speaker. I think Leadership, together with Table, can look into it and take a decision on it; so, your concern is well noted.

That notwithstanding, we will review the *Official Report* of 11th June, 2025.

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 11th June, 2025]

Hon Members, the Public Gallery is full; we have so many school children. We have six schools visiting us today, and the first school is Leklebi Senior High School. I guess I pronounced the name well, Leklebi Senior High School. Help me with the pronunciation.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, that is my constituency; they are from my constituency, and the school is “Leklebi Senior High School” from Afadjato South.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. They are led by Afenya Zena who is the Head of Department of the General Arts Department, and the school is, of course, located in the Afadjato South Constituency. They are 78 in number. You are welcome.

[Students of Leklebi Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The second school is The Saviour International School, led by Isaac Asirifi who is a teacher. The school is located in the Achiase Constituency, and they are 66 in number. Do we have the Member of Parliament for Achiase Constituency here? He is not here.

[Pupils of Saviour International School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The third school is Elmina Catholic Boys Junior High School, led by Frederick Vibaaye, a teacher. The school is located in the Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abirem Constituency. I guess the Member is here, yes. They are 59 in number.

Hon Samuel Atta-Mills, I hope you will take good care of them.

[Pupils of Elmina Catholic Boys Junior High School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member for Afadjato, I hope you will take good care of them. Wonderful.

The fourth school is Mafi Agoe D/A Basic School—

Mr Alexander Roosevelt Hottordze: Mr Speaker, it is “Mafi Agoe”. They are from my constituency.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Mafi Agoe D/A Basic School. Wonderful. They are led by Saviour Hofleku who is the headmaster, and the school is located at Central Tongu Constituency. They are

100 in number. Hon Member, I hope you would take good care of them.

Mr Hottordze: Sure, as you know.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Wonderful.

Mr Hottordze: You are welcome; *miawoe zo.*

[Pupils of Mafi Agoe D/A Basic School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We also have World Sage School. Are they not here? All right. What about the University of Ghana Business School (UGBS)?

We have UGBS, also led by Kelvin Baruch-Bannerman Williams, who is the Speaker of the Business House Junior Common Room, and the School is located in the Ayawaso West Wuogon Constituency. Did I see the Member here? Very well, I guess he will also take good care of them.

[Students from University of Ghana Business School Junior Common Room were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, all of you at the Public Gallery, I hope you are here to monitor and learn from your representatives. I will urge you to learn, and that should motivate you to also study hard, so that tomorrow, you will come and take over from us if we are not here. You are welcome, and we wish you well.

Leadership, are we taking the Urgent Questions?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, indeed, there are two Urgent Questions which stands in my name and is directed at the head of an independent constitutional body, in this case, in pursuance of Order 79, that is the Electoral Commission.

Mr Speaker, a letter came from the Electoral Commission to this House indicating that the Electoral Commissioner is unavoidably absent from the jurisdiction and, therefore, the Deputy Commissioner will be available to respond to the Questions. Mr Speaker, that would be in breach of Order 79 and with your leave, let me read Order 79.

3.15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Order 79 is headed, “Response to Question by Heads of Independent Constitutional Bodies”, and it reads:

“A Question asked of the Head of an Independent Constitutional Body shall be responded to at Committee of the Whole.”

Mr Speaker, the rule has not been relaxed and provided for that in the absence of the head of the Independent Constitutional Body, a deputy will answer the Questions. So, I am amenable to rescheduling these two Questions to abide the coming of the substantive Head so we can deal with the subject of these two Questions.

Mr Speaker, on these terms, I want to pray that the two Questions be deferred to a later date, when we have a firm date

of the availability of the Electoral Commissioner of the Republic of Ghana to respond to this matter. Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on, let me find out. I am coming. So, when we file a Question to Ministers of State—I will come to you, Hon Habib. When we file a Question to a Minister of State, do we specify that only the Minister should come and answer that Question? Do we not have instances where Deputy Ministers come to the House to answer Questions for and on behalf of their substantive Ministers?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, our rule provides that in the absence of the Ministers, the deputies will respond to Questions. In fact, by practice, we allow Deputy Ministers to respond to Questions. This is our new Standing Order, and the rules are very clear under Order 79. We cannot enlarge the interpretation of this provision to include the deputies. It is for a reason. That is why, for the first time—Hon Habib, please. These are very serious matters.

Mr Speaker, no Member on this Floor should urge on you an enlargement in terms of interpretation of the matters clearly stated under Order 79 to include deputies. So, if there are three deputies or two deputies, which of them do we speak of? That is why the rule says heads of Independent Constitutional Bodies, heads. Now, if this House intended their deputies to have a say or to have a presence on the Floor and respond to their matters, we could have said the heads or their deputies.

So, on this note, Mr Speaker, I do not think that we should litigate this matter. It does not open itself for any enlargement. Indeed, if we go to the interpretation section, which is Order 6, independent constitutional bodies mean supranational legislative bodies established—Mr Speaker, my apologies. It reads:

“Independent Constitutional Bodies include the Electoral Commission, Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice, National Commission for Civic Education, National Media Commission, Office of the Administrator of the District Assemblies Common Fund, Office of the Auditor-General, Bank of Ghana, and other bodies established to have exclusive jurisdiction in the performance of assigned functions;”

So, for instance, if by any attempt to enlarge the meaning of this provision, and I direct a question at the Administrator of the Common Fund who has no deputies, who will then come and respond to it if we accommodate such interpretation?

Mr Speaker, so the heads are the heads, and the head of an Independent Constitutional Body is *qua* the head. The deputies are not permissible under this provision. I believe that we can make progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me listen to Hon Habib.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I think the Majority Chief

Whip, in reading Order 79, did not advert his mind to Order 88(6). Mr Speaker, with your permission, I will read Order 88(6). I will start from 5 and then to 6. Order 88(5) says:

“The answer to the Question shall be read by the Minister, Member or Head of the Independent Constitutional Body to whom the question is directed.”

Mr Speaker, Order 88(6), which I emphasise, says that:

“In the absence of the Minister, Member or Head of an Independent Constitutional Body to whom the Question is directed, the Speaker may permit an authorised person to respond to the Question.”

So, the Majority Chief Whip is completely out of place. It is within our Orders that the deputies of the Heads of the Independent Constitutional Bodies, which he rightly interpreted under Order 6—If you go to Order 6, Mr Speaker, on page 4 of our rules, the Standing Orders define Independent Constitutional Bodies to include the Electoral Commission.

Mr Speaker, in this case, we are not dealing with the Head of DACF, where one would say that he does not have a deputy. We are dealing with the Electoral Commission specifically, and our rules under Order 88(6) mention the Head of the Independent Constitutional Body. So, they are here to answer the Question.

Mr Speaker, it does not lie on him or me to dictate who should answer the Question. The rules are clear, and the

rules say that if the Head is not there—I want to appeal to my Colleague, the Majority Chief Whip, that we are trading on a very dangerous ground, because the Order that gives deputy ministers the opportunity to respond to Questions in the absence of their Ministers is the same thing that gives birth to the Independent Constitutional Bodies if they also have to respond to Questions.

So, if we deny the deputies of the Independent Constitutional Body, in this case, the Electoral Commission, to answer questions, it implies that no deputy minister can come to this Chamber to answer questions on behalf of their Minister. So, Mr Speaker, I so submit that my colleague, the one who is going to ask the Question, should allow you to invite the deputy head of the Electoral Commission to answer questions he rightfully filed.

If it is the case that he is running away from his questions, that is all right. But if he is not running away from the questions, allow them to ask the questions, and then we can make progress. I so submit, Mr Speaker—*[Hear! Hear!]* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the rule is very clear. It says ‘may’. The ‘may’ is suggestive of the fact that there is no opposition. Yes, there is no opposition. Mr Speaker, I am in my 10th year in this House. They have denied the deputy Minister from responding to a Question when they protested. So, when there is no protestation. Please, I listened to Hon Habib in quietude.

When there is no protestation, I insist that the head must appear. It is my Question. There are reasons we are asking the head to come and respond to matters of policy.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us keep quiet. We cannot sit there and say no.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the provision under 88 permits you to allow the deputy to respond to the Questions if the sponsor of the Question does not protest. I am protesting that I want the substantive head to appear. When that is done, how will the Speaker permit that to be done? It says the Speaker may. That is without protestation. But I insist that for very good reasons, Mr Speaker.
3.25 p.m.

There are some matters that I will be raising that the deputy who is not the head may not be able to respond to. So, these are very serious.

Especially when status and the Constitution make the head the only returning officer in the Presidential election results that took place in that constituency in question, because my follow-up questions will be tied to the outcome of the Presidential results in the same constituency that the Parliamentary results took place. [*Hear! Hear!*] The Deputy cannot respond to those matters.

So, there are very good reasons we want the Electoral Commissioner of the Republic of Ghana. This Chamber is a common turf for her. She appears here often when it is needed, so if she is

unwell, it is fine. We will abide her coming to respond to the matter.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, my ruling is that if the owner of the Question decides that he would not ask the Question, then he has to withdraw the Question. Once the Question appears on the Order Paper, Parliament ceases ownership of the Question, and under the circumstances, we might be walking on a slippery slope, in the sense that with this discussion going on, it will imply that if a Minister of State is unable to come and respond to any Question, this House or the other Side may protest that no Deputy Minister of State is allowed to perform that function. So, under the circumstance, my ruling is that if the Deputy Commissioner has come to answer the Questions, I may allow him to respond to the Question, unless the owner of the Question decides that he is withdrawing the question. If he withdraws the Question, then the Question will not be tabled for the Deputy Commissioner to answer. But other than that, the Deputy Commissioner is capable of answering the Question. So, this is my ruling. Once the Deputy Commissioner is here, I do not think he is coming to tell us that he is not able to answer the Questions. So, if he is here, I will have to give him the opportunity. Unless the owner of the Question tells me that he is withdrawing the Question, then we will take it from there.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I intend not to challenge your ruling, but I also intend not to withdraw the Questions. So, now I am compelled to

ask the Questions. So, he should come and feature. I am ready.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Deputy Commissioner of the Electoral Commission—We are supposed to reconstitute into a Committee of the Whole.

So, Hon Members, we are constituting the House into a Committee of the Whole.

3:33 p.m. — [The House constituted into a Committee of the Whole.]

6.06 p.m.— Sitting resumed

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, Minority Leader and I engaged this morning concerning two reports by the Finance Committee. It is the Report of the Finance Committee on the Indicative Debt Restructuring Terms, which was referred to them a couple of days ago as well as the Committee's Report on the Annual Report on the Collection and Utilisation of the African Union Import Levy, 2024. So these were the two Reports we intended to lay if the Order Paper Addendum were ready.

Mr Speaker, clearly, it is not ready. So, I believe we have exhausted the Business for the day. Mr Speaker, on this note, we have not done 5 hours since 2:00 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, there are some Statements, but if you are minded to take a couple — Mr Speaker,

let us come back tomorrow and deal with the Statement and some other things. So, we pray for an adjournment.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well; then do the needful.

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker in the absence of any further Business, I beg to move that the House be adjourned till tomorrow at 2:00 p.m.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, we were expecting our Colleague to move the Motion for the House properly as a very excellent practitioner; we are not opposed to his application.

Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker — *[Interruption]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, a Motion has been moved and it has been seconded. You decided not to second it; you yielded to your Whip.

Do you want to say something?

Leader, I am told the agreement was that on Fridays — We should still stick to 2:00 p.m.? Very well.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 6.13 p.m. till Friday, 20th June, 2025, at 2.00 p.m.

